

The Bookshop at Number Nine

Book 7 of 10

A book arrives with no sender. Inside - a photograph of a face he knows.

CEFR Level A1 | Adult Graded Reader

Setting: An old bookshop in Bristol. Dan's shop at number nine, Anchor Street.

Genre: Mystery / Warm Drama

Characters

- Dan - 50. Bookseller. Quiet, organised. Has run the shop for twenty years.
- Polly - 28. His assistant. Curious and energetic.
- Ruth - 55. The sender. An old customer from twenty years ago.

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Number nine, Anchor Street, Bristol. Dan's bookshop has been here for twenty years. The sign says: NINE BOOKS - NEW AND SECOND-HAND. The shop is long and narrow. Every wall has shelves. Every shelf has books. There is a small desk near the window. Dan sits at the desk every morning. He drinks tea, reads, sorts new books. He is happy here. Today, a parcel comes in the morning post.

Dan cuts the brown paper. Inside: an old Victorian novel. Dark blue cover. Yellow pages. There is no note - except a photograph. It is black and white. A woman and a man - both young. Standing outside a bookshop. Dan looks at the sign in the photograph. It says: NINE BOOKS. He looks at the man in the photograph. The man is him. Twenty years ago.

Polly arrives at nine thirty. She looks at Dan. 'You have that face.' 'What face?' 'The face you make when something is strange.' Dan shows her the book and the photograph. 'Who is she?' 'I don't know.' 'You are in the photograph with her.' 'I know.' Dan sits down. 'I just don't remember.'

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Dan opens a parcel in his old bookshop.

Polly looks at the book. 'A Victorian novel - The Return. Published 1887. Not very common.' 'Can you find out who sent it?' 'The postmark is Bristol. No return address. Paid in cash.' Dan holds the photograph again. The woman is young - maybe mid-twenties. She has long fair hair. She is laughing. 'She looks happy,' Polly says. 'Yes,' Dan says. 'She does.'

Dan thinks. Twenty years ago he was thirty. He had just opened the shop. He was married to Anne. Anne died eight years ago. He thinks about the customers from those first years. Many faces. 'Do you keep old records?' Polly asks. 'Customer names? Sale books?' 'There is a box. In the back room. From the early years.' Polly is already walking to the back room.

The box has handwritten notebooks - records of every sale from 1998 to 2005. Polly reads out names. At the back of the 2003 notebook, there is a different section - not sales, but customers who ordered books. One entry: Ruth M. - ordered: The Return - Nov. 2003. Dan stops. 'Ruth M.' he says quietly.

Dan stands at the window with his back to Polly. He thinks. Ruth. 2003. A customer who

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Dan and Polly examine the book and photograph.

ordered a book. And then - slowly - he remembers. A woman with long fair hair. November. She was looking for *The Return*. He ordered it for her. She came to collect it three weeks later. They talked about Victorian novels, about Bristol. She came back two or three more times. Then she stopped coming.

'Her name was Ruth,' Dan says. 'She came in 2003. She was studying literature at the university. Quiet. Serious. She loved old books.' 'Did you know her well?' Polly asks. 'No. Not well. But she was a good person. I remember liking her.' 'Why did she stop coming?' Dan looks at the photograph. 'I got married that year. To Anne. I was busy.'

'If she was a student in 2003, she probably finished her degree around 2004 or 2005,' Polly says. She opens her laptop. She types: Ruth M. Bristol University Literature 2004. In ten minutes, she finds a blog called Books I Found. The writer's name: Ruth Marsh.

Polly reads from the blog. 'She writes about books. She writes well. She is in Bristol.' Dan reads the screen. The most recent post is three days ago - about a Victorian novel. Ruth writes: 'I

sent a copy of The Return to a bookshop I loved twenty years ago. I hope the owner still has the shop. I hope he still reads. I hope he is well.' Dan reads this twice. He does not speak.

Polly looks at Dan. 'She has a contact form on the blog,' she says carefully. Dan is quiet for a long time. Polly waits. 'Write to her,' Dan says. 'Tell her - tell her I got the book. Tell her thank you.' 'Anything else?' Dan picks up the photograph. 'Tell her I remember,' he says.

Ruth replies the next day: "Dear Dan. I am very glad you still have the shop. I am in Bristol - I moved back last year. I work at the university library now. I found the photograph when I was clearing my old boxes. I wanted to send something. The shop was very important to me. Ruth." Dan reads the message three times. Then he writes back.

Dan writes carefully: "Dear Ruth. Thank you for the book and the photograph. The shop is still here. You were right to send it. I needed to remember. I work every day at the desk near the window, Monday to Saturday. If you would like to come and see the shop - you are welcome. Dan." Polly reads the message before he sends it. 'Good,'

she says.

Three days later, the door opens at two in the afternoon. Dan looks up from his desk. A woman comes in. About fifty-five. Grey hair now - not fair. A little heavier than in the photograph. But she has the same eyes. Dan stands up. 'Ruth,' he says. She looks around the shop - the shelves, the ceiling, the books. Then at Dan. 'It really has not changed much,' she says.

Dan makes tea. Polly saw Ruth at the door and quietly went home early. Dan and Ruth sit at the small table near the back. Ruth holds the blue book - The Return. 'I read this at university. I could not find a copy for years. Then I found one in a second-hand shop in Edinburgh.' 'And you sent it here.' 'Yes. It felt right.' 'Why?' Dan asks. It is a genuine question. 'Because of what you said to me about it. Once. A long time ago.'

'What did I say?' Dan asks. Ruth smiles. 'You said: some books find you at the right moment. You do not choose them. They choose you.' Dan is quiet. 'I said that?' 'Yes. I was having a difficult time. I was not sure about my studies. About everything. And you said that.' 'Did it help?' 'Yes. Very much.' She looks at him. 'I think you forgot

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Dan reconnects with Ruth near the bookshop.

you said it. But I never forgot.'

The next morning, Polly arrives at nine thirty. She looks at Dan - his face is different. 'Good?' Polly says. 'Good,' Dan says. Polly hangs up her coat. She looks at the small table near the back. There are two teacups. She smiles. She says nothing. She goes to the shelf and starts sorting books. Dan goes back to his tea. He looks at the blue book - The Return - on the desk.

Ruth comes to the shop the following Tuesday. And the Tuesday after that. They have tea and talk about books - old ones and new ones. She recommends. He recommends. Sometimes they disagree. 'This one is too long,' Ruth says. 'It needs the length,' Dan says. 'Shorter is better.' 'Not always.' Polly listens from behind the shelves. She hides a smile.

Dan puts the photograph in a small frame on his desk. One morning a customer sees it. 'Is that you?' He points at the young man. 'Yes.' 'Long time ago?' 'Twenty years.' The customer looks at the woman. 'She looks happy,' he says. Dan looks at the photograph. 'Yes,' he says. 'She does.' He smiles.

Number nine, Anchor Street, Bristol. The sign says: NINE BOOKS - NEW AND SECOND-HAND. The shop has been here for twenty years. It has not changed much. Dan is at the desk. He has his tea. On Tuesday afternoons, there are two cups. Polly sorts books. She is thinking about going to library school next year. Dan does not know this yet. Outside, Anchor Street is quiet. Inside: books, tea, and the smell of old paper. Some things do not change. Some things do. And that is good too.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. second-hand	ikinci el	2. narrow	dar
3. sorts	düzenler	4. parcel	paket, koli
5. morning post	sabah postası	6. Victorian novel	Viktorya dönemi romanı
7. cover	kapak	8. edges	kenarlar
9. except	hariç	10. sign	tabela
11. strange	tuhaf	12. remember	hatırlamak
13. shows her	ona gösterir	14. postmark	posta damgası
15. cash	nakit	16. fair hair	sarışın saç
17. laughing	gülüyor	18. married	evli
19. died	öldü	20. records	kayıtlar
21. early years	ilk yıllar	22. handwritten	el yazısıyla
23. reads out	sesli okur	24. section	bölüm
25. ordered	sipariş verdi	26. entry	kayıt
27. slowly	yavaşça	28. collect	almak, teslim almak
29. stopped coming	gelmeyi bıraktı	30. studying	öğrenciydi
31. serious	ciddi	32. liking her	onu beğenmek
33. got married	evlendi	34. busy	meşgul
35. degree	lisans	36. alumni	mezun

37. types	yazar (klavyede)	38. blog	blog
39. most recent	en son	40. post	gönderi
41. sent a copy	bir kopya gönderdi	42. still has	hâlâ sahip
43. well	sağlıklı	44. contact form	iletişim formu
45. carefully	dikkatle	46. got the book	kitabı aldım
47. I remember	hatırlıyorum	48. very glad	çok memnun
49. moved back	geri döndü	50. clearing	boşaltıyordu
51. important to me	benim için önemliydi	52. needed to remember	hatırlamam gerekiyordu
53. Monday to Saturday	Pazartesi'den Cumartesiye	54. welcome	hoş geldiniz
55. looks up	başını kaldırır	56. heavier	daha kilolu
57. same eyes	aynı gözler	58. ceiling	tavan
59. really	gerçekten	60. holds	tutar
61. felt right	doğru hissettirdi	62. genuine	içten, gerçek
63. once	bir zamanlar	64. at the right moment	doğru anda
65. choose	seçmek	66. difficult time	zor dönem
67. forgot	unuttu	68. never forgot	hiç unutmadı
69. different	farklı	70. hangs up	asar (ceketini)
71. teacups	çay fincanları	72. sorting	düzenliyor
73. following Tuesday	ertesi Salı	74. recommends	tavsiye eder

75. disagree	uyuşmamak	76. too long	çok uzun
77. frame	çerçeve	78. customer	müşteri
79. points at	işaret eder	80. young man	genç adam
81. smiles	gölümser	82. library school	kütüphanecilik okulu
83. walk past	geçip gider	84. smell of old paper	eski kâğıt kokusu
85. that is good too	bu da iyidir		

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice - Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

1. parcel
- A. sipariş verdi
2. ordered
- B. paket, koli
3. narrow
- C. el yazısıyla
4. handwritten
- D. dar
5. alumni
- E. mezun
6. current
- F. güncel
7. disagree
- G. uyuşmamak
8. genuine
- H. içten, gerçek

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

parcel - photograph - twenty - forgot - important -
remember

1. A _____ arrives at Dan's shop in the morning post.
2. Inside the book, there is an old _____.
3. Dan sees himself in the photo - from _____ years ago.
4. Dan _____ what he said to Ruth - but she never forgot.

5. Ruth says the shop was very _____ to her.
6. Dan writes to Ruth to tell her he got the book and that he can _____ her now.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Dan's shop is called "Old Books." ____
2. The parcel has a return address. ____
3. Polly finds Ruth's name in an old notebook. ____
4. Ruth is a teacher at a secondary school. ____
5. Ruth moved back to Bristol last year. ____
6. At the end, Ruth visits the shop on Tuesdays. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. What is inside the parcel?
8. How does Polly find Ruth?
9. Why did Ruth stop coming to the shop in 2003?
10. What did Dan say to Ruth that she never forgot?
11. Why did Ruth send the book to Dan?
12. What does Dan write in his message to Ruth?
13. What does Polly do when she sees Ruth at the door?
14. What does Dan do with the photograph?
15. What is Polly thinking about doing next year?

Answer Key

(Alıştırımları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-D 4-C 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. parcel 2. photograph 3. twenty 4. forgot 5. important 6. remember

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. T 4. F 5. T 6. T

7. An old Victorian novel and a black-and-white photograph of Dan and a woman.

8. She searches the internet and finds Ruth's blog called "Books I Found."

9. Dan got married to Anne that year and was very busy.

10. "Some books find you at the right moment. They choose you."

11. She found the photograph and wanted to send something meaningful.

12. He thanks her, says he needed to remember, and invites her to visit.

13. She quietly takes her coat and goes home early.

14. He puts it in a small frame on his desk.

15. She is thinking about going to library school.